

areas and should definitely be given a place in any serious collection covering these areas of interest.

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Rape Work: Victims, Gender, and Emotions in Organization and Community Context

Patricia Yancey Martin, Routledge, New York, 2005, 280, ISBN 0-415-92775-7

The scope and style of this book render it an invaluable resource for anyone who works with, or is concerned about victims of rape and sexual assault. Drawing on a rich, extensive data set that represents over twenty years of research into rape work in the US, Yancey Martin provides a comprehensive, analytical and politically engaged account of the diverse practices, which constitute work with rape victims. Her descriptions of the rape work engaged in by law enforcers, prosecutors, medical personnel and victim advocates are informative and exhibit detailed understanding of the steps and processes involved in responding to rape victims. Yancey Martin's key thesis is that the organizational context in which rape work occurs, can mitigate against rape victims being treated in a responsive, supportive way and can compound their sense of victimization and violation. Throughout the work, she marshals a range of evidence to highlight the ways in which organizational interests are prioritized over those of victims resulting in dispassionate, unresponsive services, which exacerbate victim distress. Law enforcers and prosecutors focus on selecting 'good' victims and building 'strong cases', medics avoid embarrassing and emotionally draining rape examinations and the legal involvement they entail, whereas judges focus on ensuring observance of US rape law which is written from the standpoint of the rapist. The result is a range of services experienced by victims as disjointed, bureaucratic and potentially destructive. This depressing scenario of service provision for rape victims is not exclusive to the US. Research from Britain, Ireland and mainland Europe reveals similar difficulties (Lees, 1996; Ward *et al.*, 1998; Leane *et al.*, 2001), suggesting that the issue of responding to rape victims is one, which requires continuing attention. What is novel about Yancey Martin's

work is that she moves beyond the usual model of considering the responsiveness of individual professions or organizations to rape victims and analyses how discrete geographical communities address the issue of rape.

Drawing on her analysis of the network relationships among 105 organizations involved in rape work in 22 Florida communities, Yancey Martin concludes that relations among the organizations in a community are highly significant in shaping the experiences of rape victims. Her research indicates that communities with an RCC were more responsive to victims, particularly when the RCC worked as a co-ordinator facilitating direct, one-to-one, interaction between all of the organizations involved in rape work. It is noteworthy that in communities where one organization, be it an RCC or hospital or sheriff's office, dominates service co-ordination and insists that the activities of all other organisations are channelled through it, the level of community responsiveness to rape is reduced. Communities in which police and RCCs play complementary co-ordinating roles in developing victim networks proved the most responsive, particularly when police and prosecution personnel exercised leadership in rape-prevention work. Central to RCCs' work in encouraging community responsiveness to rape victims is the promotion of a feminist understanding of rape, through what Yancey Martin describes as 'discursive political work' (p. 119). This endorsement of a feminist conception of rape permeates all RCC work, be it initiatives to train professionals encountering rape victims to be more responsive, or moves to develop protocols for victim care with mainstream organizations such as police facilities, hospitals, etc. However, Yancey Martin's research indicates that RCCs take a very pragmatic approach to spreading their feminist message. Nearly, all of the RCCs she researched adopted a strategy of 'unobtrusive mobilization' (p. 101). Such a strategy avoids confronting and blaming of organizations and concentrates on forging links with them with a view to challenging rape myths, promoting an understanding of rape as a violent crime and developing service protocols and provisions which reflect this understanding.

This occupy-and-indoctrinate approach, however, has some disadvantages. Most significantly, it reduces the potential for RCCs to provide a strong public critique of unresponsive practices they become aware of in the organizations with whom they work. Indeed, as Yancey Martin points out, there is a role for the wider feminist movement to take up the discursive political work around rape, which the RCCs have pioneered. Another role, which the wider feminist movement might well assume, is that of challenging feminist organizations like RCCs to engage in a critical appraisal of their own practices. Yancey Martin's research mirrors previous work on RCCs, in its finding that African-American and in particular Hispanic/Latina victims,

are under-represented among the staff running RCCs and among the victims they work with. Furthermore, her research also suggests that RCCs that continue to rely heavily on volunteers, due to lack of funds or to a political commitment to maintain a grassroots identity, provide a less reliable and less responsive service to victims.

In conclusion, this book provides critical insights into rape work, as both professional practice and political endeavour and its accessible style and extensive research base render it a very important contribution to the literature on rape, feminist politics, community mobilization and organizational culture. Most importantly, this work highlights the significant achievement of American RCCs in prioritizing the needs of rape victims and in securing increased responsiveness to these needs. It also underlines the need for continued feminist mobilization around the issue of rape and ongoing organizational reflectivity around service provision for the vulnerable victims of this violent crime. The ultimate goal is for organizations and indeed communities to 'own rape' and to work from the premise that rape in any circumstances will not be condoned.

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No Overall Control: Experiencing Community Development in Rural Britain

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